

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

SEASON'S GREETINGS

Minutes after **Mamata Banerjee** gave Prime Minister Narendra Modi a clean chit rgearding central investigative agencies being misused against Opposition leaders, the West Bengal chief minister walked up to the Opposition benches to exchange Durga Puja greetings. She even greeted bete noire **Suvendu Adhikari**, who had defeated her in the assembly polls in March. The TMC-turned-BJP MLA, now the leader of the Opposition in the House, returned the greeting but was soon back to blasting the Trinamool Congress. The exchange was dismissed as nothing more than social courtesy, but not before the Left parties and the Congress sniffed an "understanding" between Modi and Didi.

A GOOD SPORT



When IAS officer **Navneet Sehgal**, once Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath's chief troubleshooter, was transferred from high-profile departments such as information and public relations and MSMEs to the low-key sports department, many saw it as a demotion. But Sehgal is determined to leave a mark on his new assignment. He has given officials instructions to make presentations for two more international-level stadiums—one in Purvanchal and another in western UP. He hopes to organise top-league tennis tournaments such as the Davis Cup in UP. A sports lover himself and president of the state badminton association, Sehgal wants to make UP a sports-friendly state. It may help him get back into Yogi's inner circle too.

POLITICAL ACCESSORY

On September 25, when **Rajiv Ranjan, alias Lalan Singh**, national president of the Janata Dal (United), walked into Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar's 6, K. Kamraj Lane, residence in Delhi, everyone noticed the brand new Bluetooth neckband earphone around his neck. Even the CM noticed the accessory and asked him about it. Singh said he had been getting a lot of calls and the wireless earphones were useful. With Nitish on a mission to unite the Opposition, the party chief too is getting his share of attention.



SONU KISHAN



THE RENAME GAME

Actor-turned-TDP MLA **N. Balakrishna**, son of TDP founder and legendary politician N.T. Rama Rao (NTR), is peeved with Andhra Pradesh chief minister Jagan Mohan Reddy renaming the NTR University of Health Sciences after his own father, the late Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, on September 21. Balakrishna, who was not in the House the day this happened, has warned Jagan that people and *panchaboothalu* (five elements) will dethrone him. Never mind that Jagan had renamed Krishna district after NTR earlier this year. What's bigger, a district or a university, Jagan's followers ask.

Thespian Desire



CHHINDWARA MAYOR

Chhindwara mayor **Vikram Ahakey**, 31, the youngest ever in Madhya Pradesh to get that position, recently took the stage, but not to deliver any rousing speech. The Congressman, who featured in the party's mayoral victory in Chhindwara after two decades, was playing one of the kings attending Sita's *swayamvar* in the 134-year-old Chhindwara Ramleela. Asked about his dramatic turn, Ahakey said it was his contribution to keeping religion and culture alive. But we thought that was a BJP preserve.

Kaushik Deka *with Romita Datta, Prashant Srivastava, Rahul Noronha, Amarnath K. Menon and Amitabh Srivastava*